God Be Merciful to Me a Sinner

Luke 18:9-14 (KJV)

Scripture

Luke 18:9-14

[9] And he spake this parable unto certain which trusted in themselves that they were righteous, and despised others: [10] Two men went up into the temple to pray; the one a Pharisee, and the other a publican. [11] The Pharisee stood and prayed thus with himself, God, I thank thee, that I am not as other men are, extortioners, unjust, adulterers, or even as this publican. [12] I fast twice in the week, I give tithes of all that I possess. [13] And the publican, standing afar off, would not lift up so much as his eyes unto heaven, but smote upon his breast, saying, God be merciful to me a sinner. [14] I tell you, this man went down to his house justified rather than the other: for every one that exalteth himself shall be abased; and he that humbleth himself shall be exalted.

Outline

1. Pride trusts itself and looks down on others

They trusted in themselves that they were _____.

Pride measures itself against _____ people.

Read: Luke 18:9-12; Proverbs 16:18; Romans 12:3

2. Humility comes empty-handed

God be _____ to me a sinner.

The publican came to God with nothing but his _____.

Read: Luke 18:13; Psalm 51:17; Isaiah 57:15

3. God exalts the humble

This man went down to his house _____ rather than the other.

He that humbleth himself shall be _____.

Read: Luke 18:14; James 4:6; 1 Peter 5:5

Discussion questions

1. What was good about the Pharisee's life? What was wrong with his prayer?

2. In what subtle ways do we compare ourselves with others to feel better?

3. Why is "God be merciful to me a sinner" such a powerful prayer?

4. How can we hold high standards without falling into the Pharisee's pride?

This week

Each day this week, pray the publican's prayer slowly and sincerely. When you catch yourself thinking "at least I'm not like them," stop and pray for that person instead.